

Course Information

Course Number: PHIL 2305
Course Name: Contemporary Ethical Issues
Section: tbd
Semester: tbd
Time: Asynchronous
Location: Asynchronous
Credit Hours: 3

Instructor Information

Instructor: Professor Hill, M.A.
Email: Hill.Justin.Andrew@gmail.com
Office Hours: tbd
Website: HillJ.net
Annotations: HillJ.net/annotations/
Lectures: HillJ.net/teaching/phil-2305/
[YouTube PHIL 2305 Playlist](#)

Communication Expectations

Email or LMS are preferred. LMS messages will send me extra notifications, so it may be faster. I will try to respond within 48 hours, but please allow up to 3 business days (72 hours, M-F) for a response. Please plan ahead and communicate early, as I must navigate multiple avenues of thought, activity, and projects.

But I also mean levels in what counts as political. As you dare to witness police arresting people, or dare to ask a woman who is saying “no” to a man’s hold whether she’s all right, whether she wants to leave, you notice that it is quite different to do that than to organize a demonstration against Anglo takeover of land and water in the U.S. Southwest. It is all beyond the pale, but the latter is more easily understood as political—it is afforded a kind of sociality—that the others may lack. So, there are levels of disruption, levels of resistance, in terms of the political sense that the act makes. Foundations that fund political projects often look for political activity that makes a particular kind of “within-bounds” sense. It is important to take stock of the ease of acceptance, since there is a need to try to roam more deeply into the social to understand who’s paying for one’s acceptability.

*I also mean levels of motility: sometimes you are stuck in a chair and the tiny movements in your hands are a level of intense resistance that requires a closeness of understanding to sense tactually the forcefulness of the motility. Sometimes you walk miles in a closeness of people giving birth to an intention that was not in any of us alone, with banners and other crafted signs of our impudence. **Everyone in the crowd sensing in the sounds coming out of our bodies and our feet hitting the ground, and the bumping into each other, the carrying of the signs still fresh or used over and over, but made from our own cloth, the forcefulness and largeness of our motility.***

— Lugones, *Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes*, p. 2.

Course Description

Introduction to the philosophical examination of contemporary moral issues. Emphasis on critical examination and comparison of different perspectives on the rightness and wrongness of various actions typically considered morally problematic in the contemporary world. Topics covered may include abortion, capital punishment, discrimination and prejudice, and environmental issues.

Student Resources and Basic Needs

Students are humans first. To learn effectively you must have basic security: a roof over your head, a safe place to sleep, enough food to eat, and other necessary external goods. If you or another student you know are having trouble with any of those things, please talk with me or use the campus resources available.

Course Requirements

- Week 1 Launch
10%; 100 points.
 - **1.5%; 15 points:** Icebreakers [Week 1 Exit Ticket]
 - **6.0%; 60 points:** Unit 0: Syllabus Quiz
 - **2.5%; 25 points:** Unit 0: Respondus LockDown Practice Quiz
- Webcam-Recorded Timed Essay Exams
120 minutes; 1500 words (i.e., ~5 pp double-spaced);
Paragraphs pre-built piecemeal from weekly Exit Tickets (see below).

60%; 600 points [15% each; 150 points each].
 - Unit 1: V. F. Cordova, *How It Is*.
 - Unit 2: Aldo Leopold, *Sand County Almanac*.
 - Unit 3: bell hooks, *Belonging: A Culture of Place*.
 - Unit 4: Maria Lugones, *Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes*. [Final.]
- Daily Work
30%; 300 points.
 - Exit Tickets (each week)
[Short Responses to Guiding Questions]
 - **18%; 45 points per unit.**
 - 2-5 sentences each week.
 - Two attempts, Pass/Fail [P/F]. Second attempt welcome even after week's end.
These short responses pipeline directly into pieces of your unit essay exam.
 - Handwritten Annotations (per unit)
[Print Assigned Readings, Annotate/Underline/Highlight, and Scan]

- **12%; 30 points per unit.**
- 2/3 of unit annotated.
- Study Teacher Exemplar Annotations [TEA] for further guidance.
- Extra Credit
+10%; 100 points extra.
 - **5%:** Response to Book Reviews on Policing, Colonialism, and Surveillance Capitalism:
— Antony Loewenstein's *The Palestine Laboratory*, 10 pp.; or
— Steve Martinot's *Police Brutality*, 5 pp. [November 8; Unit 4]
 - **5%:** *Thinking in Transit* by Megan Craig and Edward S. Casey [November 22; Unit 4]

Webcam-recorded timed essay exams (120 minutes, 1500 words), with access to your printed annotations, open on Monday, 12:01am, the week they are assigned and will close End of Day Sunday, 11:59pm. Tech issues are expected to be tested and problem-solved beforehand, so plan ahead with notes and practices.

In short, watch weekly lecture videos, study the assigned primary sources, and study for webcam essays.

Reading List

V. F. Cordova, *How It Is: The Native American Philosophy of V. F. Cordova*, ed. Kathleen Dean Moore, Kurt Peters, Ted Jojola, and Amber Lacy (Tucson: University of Arizona Press, 2007).

Aldo Leopold, *A Sand County Almanac: And Sketches Here and There*, illus. Charles W. Schwartz (London/Oxford/New York: Oxford University Press, 1949).

bell hooks, *Belonging: A Culture of Place* (New York/London: Routledge of Taylor & Francis Group, 2019 [2009]).

María Lugones, *Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes: Theorizing Coalition against Multiple Oppressions*, (Laham/New York/Boulder/Oxford: Rowman and Littlefield Publishers, Inc., 2003).

Extra Credit Assignment:

Megan Craig and Edward S. Casey, *Thinking in Transit: Explorations of Life in Motion* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2025).

Course Learning Outcomes

Students will be given the opportunity to:

- 1) (*Knowledge Outcomes*)
 - a) become familiar with fundamental philosophical concepts;
 - b) become familiar with major philosophical traditions;
 - c) develop the ability to critically interpret difficult philosophical texts;

- 2) (*Skill Outcomes*)
 - a) develop the ability to reason and write critically about difficult philosophical texts and issues;
 - b) develop the ability to teach themselves from source texts without background knowledge;
 - 3) (*Value Outcomes*)
 - a) reflect critically about ethical, political, aesthetic, and metaphysical (meta-ethical) issues;
 - b) reflect critically about the value of knowledge and truth;
 - 4) (*Citizenship and Professionalism Outcomes*)
 - a) develop professionalism regarding punctuality, communication, and deliverables;
 - b) develop commonly agreed upon citizenship virtues and characteristics; and
 - c) develop the ability to understand contradictory perspectives and harmonize stakeholders.
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Grading Policy

Please refer to the current University Catalog for additional information regarding grades and course withdrawal policies. For this course, (i) weekly exit ticket short responses to the main idea or a choice of guiding questions, are graded on Pass/Fail [P/F] for accuracy, with two attempts; and (ii) webcam-recorded timed essay exams are graded according to the following scale (adapted from Dr. Robin James):

A (100)	Thorough and critical understanding of the issues – subtly summarizes the major issues while also offering insightful interpretation. Outstanding argumentation, organization, and writing (fluid presentation of ideas). No misunderstandings. Clearly above and beyond expectations. <i>Excellent presentation of key ideas.</i>
B (85)	Above average understanding, not as creative or exegetical as an A level product, nor does it capture all the ‘complexities’ of the issues. A thorough recapitulation of the text and/or discussion. Adequate argumentation, organization, and writing, with few presentational complications. <i>No misunderstandings of key ideas.</i>
C (75)	Basic understanding, <i>marked by one or more significant errors or mis-readings.</i> Confused, disorganized writing that may address lots of information, but does not thematize or interpret it. Does not respond directly to all components of prompt.
D (65)	Very basic grasp of the material, presented in a highly confused manner.
F (50)	No comprehension of the material, and/or an utterly incomprehensible paper.
M/INC (0)	Missing/Incomplete/AI-Use. All earnest efforts receive a minimum grade of 50.

Grading Weight Distribution

This class follows a 1000-point structure. However, note that there are 1100 total points available in the class, meaning there is an additional 10% worth of extra credit available in this course. Your grade will be categorized into buckets: A = 895+ points; B = 795-894.99 points; C = 695-794.99 points, etc.

The following point breakdown will be used to calculate your numerical grade:

{1100 points possible w/ extra credit} 1100 points / 1000 points

Webcam-Recorded Timed Essay Exams:	600 points	/ 1000 points
Unit 1: Cordova, <i>How It Is</i>	150 points	
Unit 2: Leopold, <i>A Sand County Almanac</i>	150 points	
Unit 3: hooks, <i>Belonging</i>	150 points	
Unit 4: Lugones, <i>Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes</i> [Final]	150 points	
Weekly Work:	300 points	/ 1000 points
Exit Tickets [Short Responses to Guiding Questions]	180 points	
Handwritten Annotations	120 points	
Week 1 Launch	100 points	/ 1000 points
Icebreakers [Week 1 Exit Ticket]	15 points	
Unit 0: Syllabus Quiz	60 points	
Unit 0: Respondus LockDown Practice Quiz	25 points	
Extra Credit:	100 points	/ 1000 points
Reflections on Colonialism, Surveillance, and Policing	50 points	
<i>Thinking in Transit</i> by Craig and Casey	50 points	

I reserve the right to curve exams but am more likely to create an extra credit debrief targeting specifics.

Grading Feedback Expectations

I will return grades via Canvas within three weeks after the exam date. For P/F Exit Ticket grading, I will try to grade your first attempt early so you can revise, so submit your first attempt early then let me know.

Late Work and Make-Up Work Policy

If something comes up that will interfere with your engaging class, **especially** for any of our four exam dates, please let me know sooner rather than later. However, if there is a present emergency, please deal with that first and contact me later — you need not, for example, email me from the emergency room.

Missing exams may be taken late, until the end of Week 14, but will be graded down by five letter grades (e.g., -50%). Missing exams taken late *until the end of Week 12* will be graded down by three letter grades (e.g., -30%), to encourage catching up early. Note the third exam can only be made-up at **-50%** and the final cannot be made-up. Exams missed for excused absences can of course be taken without deduction.

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

AI use is not permitted in this course. AI use will result in an “M/INC” grade designation of 0 points, as this course is intended to teach you to think for yourself and to communicate your thinking without aid.

Did you know AI causes (often rural) water depletion at its industrial data centers? Your brains can utilize 16 ounces of water (the amount consumed per query/prompt) better than the AI data centers can do so.

Course Schedule

Date	HTA Episode	Essential Readings	Assignments Due
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Unit 0:
Introduction / Beginning Cordova, *How It Is*.

0.5 weeks

W1 08.17-23	0.1 – 0.4, 19.1	Meet Your Professor. Syllabus. Essay Exams. Exit Tickets. Icebreakers.	
	<i>Unit 0 Exam.</i> <i>Begin Unit 1.</i> <i>HTA 20.1-2</i>	Unit 0 Exam, Syllabus Quiz. Opens Wednesday; closes Sunday, EOD. Unit 0 Quiz, Respondus LockDown Browser. Opens Wednesday, closes Sunday, EOD. V. F. Cordova, <i>How It Is: The Native American Philosophy of V. F. Cordova</i> , Front Matter and beginning of “I. Bridges,” pp. vii-18 [OER PDF pp. 14-57].	Unit 0 Syllabus Quiz due End of Week 1.

Unit 1:
Indigenous [Jicarilla Apache] Worlding, Seeing, and Ethical Being

V. F. Cordova, *How It Is: The Native American Philosophy of V. F. Cordova*.
3 weeks.

W2 08.24-30	20.3-5	Ibid., cont. Cordova, <i>How It Is</i> , continuing and finishing “I. Bridges” pp. 19-45 [OER PDF pp. 58-103].	
	21.1-3	Ibid., “II. Windows,” pp. 47-83 [OER PDF pp. 104-64].	Guiding Questions due EOW, Weekly. [Annotations due End of Each Unit.]
W3 08.31-09.06	22.1-3	Ibid., “III. What is the World?,” pp. 85-129 [OER PDF pp. 165-236].	

Date	HTA Episode	Essential Readings	Assignments Due
		Ibid., “IV. What is the Human?,” pp. 131-79 [OER PDF pp. 237-317].	
W4 09.07-13	Unit 1 Exam	Ibid., “V. What is the Role of the Human in the World?,” pp. 181-232 [OER PDF pp. 318-400].	
		Unit 1 Exam: Viola Faye Cordova, <i>How It Is: The Native American Philosophy of V. F. Cordova</i>. Opens on Monday, September 7, 9a, and closes on Sunday, September 13, End of Day [EOD].	Unit 1 Essay Exam, 120min, due 09.13. U1 Annotations.

Unit 2:
Ecology, Biodiversity, and Husbandry: Environmental Ethics

Aldo Leopold, *A Sand County Almanac: And Sketches Here and There*.
3 weeks.

W5 09.14-20		Aldo Leopold, <i>A Sand County Almanac: And Sketches Here and There</i> , Front Matter, “Part I: A Sand County Almanac,” pp. vii-40.	
		Ibid., “Part I: A Sand County Almanac,” pp. 41-92.	
W6 09.21-27	Extra Credit 18.1-3	Ibid., “Part II: Sketches Here and There,” pp. 93-122.	
		Ibid., “Part II: Sketches Here and There,” pp. 122-62.	
W7 09.28-10.04	Unit 2 Exam	Ibid., “Part III: The Upshot,” pp. 163-226	
		Unit 2 Exam: Aldo Leopold, <i>A Sand County Almanac: And Sketches Here and There</i>. Opens on Monday, September 28, 9a, and closes on Sunday, October 4, EOD.	Unit 2 Essay Exam, 120min, due 10.04. U2 Annotations.

Unit 3:
Black Appalachian [Kentuckian] Worlding, Memory, Racialization, and Place-Culture Ethics

bell hooks, *Belonging: A Culture of Place*.
3 weeks.

Date	HTA Episode	Essential Readings	Assignments Due
W8 10.05-11		bell hooks, <i>Belonging: A Culture of Place</i> , Ch. 1-4, e.g., “Preface: To Know Where I’m Going,” “Kentucky Is My Fate,” “Moved By Mountains,” and “Touching the Earth,” pp. 1-40.	
		Ibid., Ch. 5-7, e.g., “Reclamation and Reconciliation,” “To Be Whole and Holy,” “Again — Segregation Must End,” pp. 41-88.	
W9 10.12-18		Ibid., Ch. 8-11, e.g., “Representations of Whiteness in the Black Imagination,” “Drive Through Tobacco,” “Earthbound: On Solid Ground,” and “An Aesthetic of Blackness: Strange and Oppositional,” pp. 89-134.	
		Ibid., Ch. 12-17, e.g., “Inspired Eccentricity,” “A Place Where the Soul Can Rest,” “Aesthetic Inheritances: History Worked by Hand,” “Piecing It All Together,” “On Being a Kentucky Writer,” and “Returning to the Wound,” pp. 135-83.	
W10 10.19-25	Unit 3 Exam	Ibid., Ch. 18-21, e.g., “Healing Talk: A Conversation,” “Take Back the Night — Remake the Present,” “Habits of the Heart,” “A Community of Care,” pp. 184-230.	
		Unit 3 Exam: bell hooks, <i>Belonging: A Culture of Place</i>. Opens on Monday, October 26, 9a, and closes on Sunday, November 1, EOD.	Unit 3 Essay Exam, 120min, due 10.25. U3 Annotations.

Unit 4:

Survival Strategies for Organizing and Coalition-Work through Multiple Selves

María Lugones, *Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes: Theorizing Coalition against Multiple Oppressions*.

5 weeks.

W11 10.26-11.01		María Lugones, <i>Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes: Theorizing Coalition against Multiple Oppressions</i> , Preface and Introduction, pp. ix-39.	
		Ibid., Ch. 1, “ <i>Hablando Cara a Cara</i> / Speaking Face to Face: An Exploration of Ethnocentrist Racism,” pp. 40-51.	All Missing Exams Due for -30% Off.

Date	HTA Episode	Essential Readings	Assignments Due
W12 11.02-08		Ibid., Ch. 2-3, “Structure/Anti-structure and Agency Under Oppression,” and “On the Logic of Pluralist Feminism,” pp. 52-75.	
		Ibid., Ch. 4, “Playfulness, ‘World’-Traveling, and Loving Perception,” pp. 76-100.	+5%: Response to Reviews on Policing and Surveillance, due EOW12, 11.08.
W13 11.09-15		Lugones, <i>Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes</i> , Ch. 5, “Hard-to-Handle Anger,” pp. 102-18. Anne Carson, <i>Men in the Off Hours</i> , “Dirt and Desire: An Essay on the Phenomenology of Female Pollution in Antiquity,” pp. 1-7.	
		Lugones, <i>Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes</i> , Ch. 6, “Purity, Impurity, and Separation,” pp. 120-48.	
W14 11.16-22		Ibid., Ch. 7, “Boomerang Perception and the Colonizing Gaze: Ginger Reflections on Horizontal Hostility,” pp. 150-64.	
		Ibid., Ch. 8, “ <i>El Pasar Discontinuo de la Cachapera / Tortillera del Barrio a la Barra al Movimiento</i> / The Discontinuous Passing of the Cachapera / Tortillera from the Barrio to the Bar to the Movement,” pp. 166-80.	+5%: Thinking In Transit by Craig and Casey, due EOW14, 11.22.
W15 11.23-29		Ibid., Ch. 9, “Enticements and Dangers of Community and Home for a Radical Politics,” pp. 182-205.	
		Ibid., Ch. 10, “Tactical Strategies of the Streetwalker / <i>Estrategias Tácticas de la Callejera</i> ,” pp. 206-37.	All Missing Exams Due for -50% Off.

Final Exams

0.5-1 weeks

W16 11.30	Reading Day	No class due to Reading Day. Office Hours by appointment via Zoom (please utilize!).	
12.01--07	Final Exam	Unit 4 Exam, Lugones, <i>Pilgrimages / Peregrinajes</i> (Final). Opens on Tuesday, December 1, 9a, and closes on Monday, December 7, EOD.	Unit 4 Essay Exam, 120min, due 12.07. U4 Annotations.

Important Dates

- **Holidays and No-Class Days**
 - September 7: Labor Day Holiday. University Closed.
 - November 25: No classes. University open until 5pm.
 - November 26-29: Thanksgiving Holiday. University closed.

- **Grade-related Dates (Major Assessments)**
 - *August 23: Syllabus Quiz [Unit 0]*
 - *August 23: Practice Respondus! [Unit 0]*
 - *September 13: Cordova Essay Exam [Unit 1]*
 - *October 4: Leopold Essay Exam [Unit 2]*
 - *October 25: hooks Essay Exam [Unit 3]*
 - *December 1-7: Lugones Essay Exam [Unit 4; Final]*
 - **Grade-related Dates (Extra Credit)**
 - *November 8: Surveillance Policing Book Reviews +5%*
 - *November 22: Thinking In Transit by Craig and Casey +5%*
 - **Grade-related Dates (Make-Ups)**
 - *November 1: All Missing Essay Exams Due for -30%*
 - *November 29: All Missing Essay Exams Due for -50%*
 - **Finals Week and Commencement**
 - *November 24: Last Day of Class*
 - *November 30: Reading Day*
 - *December 1-7: Final Exam*
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Learning Resources

My Office Hours are listed above; you are always welcome to ask me questions; I encourage discourse. You are welcome to stop by to ask about assigned readings, continue class discussions, get feedback on essays and term papers in advance, get clarity with the assigned reading, or meet my German Shepherd.

[The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy \(SEP\)](#) is better than AI (*use Ctrl+F to find keywords instead of AI*). This is a great secondary source if you are struggling with the primary sources assigned in class. You can also use the SEP to help identify promising secondary sources, topics for term papers, and the broader discourse, context, and interpretation around assigned primary sources, both for reading and for writing.

Disclaimer

I reserve the right to alter this syllabus and modify the information given above at any time during the semester. All changes will be announced via the LMS, which should hopefully forward to your email.

Texas Apartment Association: Resources for Renters; Know Your Housing Rights

The website for the Texas Apartment Association at [TAA.org](https://www.taa.org) offers lots of resources. Know your rights!
